Many Ways to Say It

Civic Skill: Voice & Participation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 5 (Communicating) & Outcome 1 (Identity) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will discover that ideas and feelings can be expressed through many modes beyond speech — drawing, gesture, sound, and movement — building respect for the many 'voices' children use (General Comment No. 12; Murray, 2019).

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can show an idea without using words.
- I can guess what someone else is showing without them speaking.
- I can name at least three ways people can share what they think.

MATERIALS

- A set of 'voice cards' showing a mouth, a hand drawing, a dancing body, a face, an instrument, and a pointing finger
- Simple percussion instruments (shaker, triangle, drum)
- Drawing materials
- Picture book: 'The Dot' by Peter H. Reynolds

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. OPENING (3 min): 'Today we're going to play with all our voices — not just our mouth voice.' Show the voice cards and name each one together.

2. BOOK READ-ALOUD (7 min): Read 'The Dot.' Discuss: 'Vashti didn't use words to show what she was feeling — she made a mark. What are other ways we could show an idea?'

3. GUESS MY WAY GAME (6 min): One child picks a voice card and silently expresses an idea that way (e.g., dances how they feel about their best friend, draws how they feel about rain). Others guess. Rotate through several children.

4. VOICE STATIONS (8 min): Small groups rotate through drawing, movement, and instrument stations, each expressing 'something I like about our room.' Educator

narrates without translating into words for the child: 'I see you showing us something with your whole body.'

5. GALLERY LISTEN (4 min): Walk around together and 'listen' to what was made at each station. 'We used lots of different voices today. All of them counted.'

EXTENSIONS

- Introduce a few simple sign-language greetings and use them daily
- Connect explicitly to any child in the room who communicates primarily through gesture, sound, or image
- Create an ongoing 'Many Voices' display combining drawings, photos of movement, and recorded sounds

ASSESSMENT

- Note which modality each child gravitates toward, and whether this shifts across the session
- Observe which children successfully interpret a peer's non-verbal expression
- Learning story: document a moment where a child expressed a clear idea without using any words

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Which children communicate most freely through non-speech modes? How well does your daily practice notice this?
- Did the 'guessing' game reveal ideas that speech alone might have missed?
- How could you widen what counts as 'listening' in your room to include more of these voices, every day?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 5 (Communicating) & Outcome 1 (Identity). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.